The Truman Doctrine

President Harry S. Truman · Address to Joint Session of Congress · March 12, 1947

Source: Harry S. Truman, Address to Congress (March 12, 1947), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

When the British announced in February 1947 that they could no longer afford to support anti-communist governments in Greece and Turkey, Truman asked Congress for $400 million to fill the gap. To get the bill through, he framed the request as a broad new doctrine: the U.S. would 'support free peoples' resisting subjugation. The Truman Doctrine inaugurated the policy of 'containment' that would shape U.S. foreign policy for the next 40+ years.

Connect: Truman framed U.S. aid as protecting 'free peoples' from 'subjugation.' Compare his framing to Wilson's 'make the world safe for democracy' (Class 39). Are these the same argument, 30 years apart?

Key Passages

Two ways of life

> At the present moment in world history nearly every nation must choose between alternative ways of life. The choice is too often not a free one. One way of life is based upon the will of the majority … The second way of life is based upon the will of a minority forcibly imposed upon the majority. It relies upon terror and oppression, a controlled press and radio; fixed elections, and the suppression of personal freedoms.

The Doctrine

> I believe that it must be the policy of the United States to support free peoples who are resisting attempted subjugation by armed minorities or by outside pressures. I believe that we must assist free peoples to work out their own destinies in their own way. I believe that our help should be primarily through economic and financial aid which is essential to economic stability and orderly political processes.

Stakes

> Should we fail to aid Greece and Turkey in this fateful hour, the effect will be far reaching to the West as well as to the East. We must take immediate and resolute action. I therefore ask the Congress to provide authority for assistance to Greece and Turkey in the amount of $400,000,000 for the period ending June 30, 1948.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Early Cold War: Britain could no longer aid Greece (civil war with communists) or Turkey (Soviet pressure), and the U.S.-Soviet wartime alliance had collapsed.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, which had to approve $400 million in aid, and the American public, which had to be convinced to accept global commitments.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Harry Truman, a Democrat who saw Soviet communism as a threat to freedom and wanted to contain it.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — identify & explain a Cold War policy: Identify ONE specific Cold War policy that grew from the Truman Doctrine.
2. Why did Truman frame a narrow Greece-Turkey aid request as a global doctrine?
3. Identify ONE later application of the Truman Doctrine (Korea, Vietnam, Cuba, Afghanistan).